

**CDC and dog importation to the United States: analysis of the 2024
Interim Final Rule and the DogBot system**

Jessica Ysabel Camacho Garcia, M.V.Z., CMVP 12434

Zoovet Travel, Trujillo, Peru

ORCID: 0009-0002-6837-5311

Carlos Eduardo Ravello Joo, Arquitectura Semántica

Zoovet Travel, Trujillo-Lima, Peru

ORCID: 0009-0007-5631-7436

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Abstract

Objective. To analyze the regulatory framework for dog importation to the United States established by the CDC 2024 Interim Final Rule, its country-of-origin classification criteria, and differential requirements based on canine rabies risk. **Method.** Technical review of current CDC regulations, the DogBot classification system, and microchip, vaccination, serology and documentation requirements applicable to dogs from high-risk countries such as Peru. **Results.** Dogs from high-risk countries — a category that includes Peru — must comply with: ISO microchip, US vaccination or complete primary series with RFFIT/FAVN ≥ 0.5 IU/mL, and in some cases entry exclusively through CDC-approved facilities (ACF). **Conclusion.** The 2024 CDC system represents the most complex canine importation framework implemented by the US, with direct consequences for export processes from Latin America.

Keywords: CDC, dog importation, canine rabies, DogBot, RFFIT, high-risk countries, ACF, Peru, Latin America

In August 2024, the CDC Interim Final Rule came into force, modernizing the framework for canine importation into the USA. It introduced the DogBot pre-arrival registration portal and established differentiated requirements based on dog-mediated rabies virus variant (DMRVV) risk. This article provides a technical analysis of its structure and implications for exporters from Peru.

Jessica Ysabel Camacho Garcia, M.V.Z., CMVP 12434 -- Zoovet Travel, Trujillo, Peru · ORCID: 0009-0002-6837-5311

Section 1 -- Background: why the CDC reformed the rules in 2024

Prior to August 2024, dog importation into the United States was governed primarily by Title 42 of the Code of Federal Regulations (42 CFR Part 71), a framework designed in the 1950s with very limited capacity for real-time documentary verification. The absence of a centralized pre-arrival registration system allowed animals with fraudulent or incomplete documentation to enter the country before authorities could effectively intervene.

Between 2021 and 2023, the CDC documented multiple cases of imported dogs carrying falsified rabies vaccination certificates, particularly from Eastern European countries and Latin America, including Peru. In several of these cases, animals presented rabies-neutralizing antibody titres inconsistent with the declared vaccination history, representing a genuine risk of reintroducing the dog-mediated rabies virus variant (DMRVV) into a country that officially eradicated this variant in the 1970s.

1.1 Applicable legal framework

The CDC's authority to regulate animal importation derives from the Public Health Service Act (42 U.S.C. § 264), which empowers the Secretary of Health and Human Services to establish regulations to prevent the introduction of communicable diseases from abroad. The Interim Final Rule published in the Federal Register on May 14, 2024 (effective August 1, 2024) replaced the previous regime by establishing three fundamental innovations: binary country classification by DMRVV risk, mandatory pre-arrival digital

registration (DogBot), and a network of approved confinement facilities (ACF, Animal Care Facilities) to manage non-compliance situations.

1.2 The DMRVV classification and Peru's position

The central concept of the new regulation is the distinction between countries with documented DMRVV presence and countries where this variant has been eradicated or was never present. Peru appears on the high-risk DMRVV list, meaning that dogs originating from or with a recent history of residence in Peru are subject to the full serological verification protocol, regardless of how long they may have been living outside the country.

Critical point A dog born in Peru but living in Spain for the past three years is still treated as originating from a high-risk DMRVV country when traveling to the USA. The country of birth or first origin history is determinative. Always verify the animal's complete history with the relevant consular authorities before assuming a risk category.

Section 2 -- Technical requirements under the 2024 rule

2.1 Identification: mandatory microchip with correct sequence

Every dog imported into the USA must carry an ISO 11784/11785 microchip implanted before the rabies vaccination that will be used as the basis for the export RFFIT. This sequence is non-negotiable: if the microchip was implanted after the vaccine, the vaccination history associated with that microchip is invalid for export purposes, and the protocol must be restarted with a new primary vaccination post-microchip.

The microchip number is the traceability element that links the animal to its vaccination certificate, RFFIT result, DogBot registration, and health certificate. Any discrepancy between these documents generates a conditional or non-compliant DogBot classification, with direct consequences on entry conditions.

2.2 The DogBot portal: mandatory pre-arrival registration

DogBot (available at dogs.cdc.gov) is the CDC's online pre-arrival registration platform that must be completed before boarding. Registration enables the system to automatically classify the animal and generates a QR code that must be presented at the port of entry alongside physical documentation. Registration must be completed at least two weeks before the flight, though it is strongly recommended to begin at least one month in advance to accommodate any data entry errors or requests for additional documentation.

DogBot requires: ISO microchip number, country of origin and transit countries, rabies vaccination history (commercial product name, batch number, administration date, expiry date), RFFIT result if applicable (laboratory, extraction date, analysis date, titre in IU/mL), certifying veterinarian data, flight date and number, and US port of entry. The platform performs automatic chronological consistency validations and rejects registrations where the microchip→vaccine→serology sequence is incoherent.

DogBot Classifications

The system issues three possible classifications:

- Compliant: the animal meets all requirements. Direct entry without additional health restrictions.
- Conditional: the animal has a pending requirement or incomplete documentation. Requires inspection at destination and possible temporary confinement until resolved.
- Non-compliant: the animal does not meet fundamental requirements. Can only enter through a CDC-approved ACF.

2.3 Country classification: high risk vs. DMRVV-free

The CDC periodically updates the list of countries classified as high-risk for DMRVV. For countries on this list (including Peru), the full protocol requires: ISO microchip, rabies vaccination with a registered product, a minimum 30-day waiting period after primary vaccination before blood collection for RFFIT, RFFIT at a USDA-approved laboratory with result ≥ 0.5 IU/mL, and DogBot registration with all documentation.

For DMRVV-free countries, requirements are significantly lower: microchip and vaccination certificate without the need for RFFIT, though DogBot registration remains mandatory.

2.4 Restrictions for puppies

Dogs under 6 months of age cannot be imported into the USA from high-risk DMRVV countries under any circumstances. Between 6 and 12 months, importation is possible only if the full primary vaccination and RFFIT protocol has been completed with a compliant result. This age restriction is one of the most frequent causes of import denial from Peru, as many owners are unaware that the process must begin before the puppy reaches 5 months of age in order to travel before it turns one year old.

Age restriction: critical point for puppies If your dog is under 6 months at the time of the planned trip, exportation to the USA from Peru is not possible. Plan with a minimum of 8 months of lead time from the animal's birth to complete the full protocol (primary vaccination + 30 days + RFFIT + DogBot registration + endorsed certificate).

References

The Rapid Fluorescent Focus Inhibition Test (RFFIT) is the gold-standard assay for determining the titre of rabies virus-neutralizing antibodies (rVNA) in animal serum. The internationally recognized protective threshold (OIE/WOAH, CDC, USDA) is 0.5 IU/mL. This value does not necessarily represent the individual animal's clinical protection threshold, but rather the minimum documentary standard that regulatory bodies accept as evidence of adequate post-vaccination immune response.

No Peruvian laboratory is currently approved by USDA to perform RFFIT with validity for importation into the USA. The animal's serum must be collected in Peru (by a licensed veterinarian) and shipped refrigerated by international courier to one of the approved US laboratories. The main ones are the Kansas State Veterinary Diagnostic Laboratory (KSVDL) in Manhattan, Kansas, and Auburn University's laboratory in Alabama. KSVDL is most commonly used by Peruvian exporters due to its turnaround times (7-10 business days) and its established protocols for South American shipments.

The shipping process requires: separated serum tube (minimum 2 mL), cold chain (4°C), laboratory international submission form, and temporary import under USDA exemption for diagnostic samples. The cold chain during air transit is critical: samples arriving partially thawed may be rejected or produce invalid results.

The 30-day window between administration of the primary rabies vaccine (or booster after a lapsed schedule) and blood collection for RFFIT is not arbitrary: it corresponds to the minimum time for the primary humoral immune response to reach the 0.5 IU/mL threshold. Collecting blood before this period will, with high probability, produce a result <0.5 IU/mL, which invalidates that serological determination and requires repeating the RFFIT after revaccination and a new 30-day wait.

Technical note: booster vs. primary vaccination If the animal has a valid prior vaccination schedule (not lapsed) and receives a booster dose, the 30-day waiting period still

applies from the booster date. However, the anamnestic response typically produces higher titres and more rapidly than the primary response. The decision to use a booster or restart from scratch depends on documentary history and the expiry date of the previous vaccine.

The health certificate for export to the USA must be completed on APHIS Form 7001 or its USDA-recognized equivalent. This form must be completed by a licensed veterinarian (in Peru, a SENASA-accredited veterinarian for exports) and must include: animal identification (species, breed, sex, age, color, microchip number), rabies vaccination data (product name, manufacturer, batch number, administration date, expiry date), and RFFIT results (laboratory, extraction date, analysis date, titre in IU/mL).

The endorsement is the validation that USDA APHIS applies to the veterinary certificate. In Peru, the endorsement process requires first validation by SENASA and then endorsement by the corresponding USDA APHIS representation. The certificate has a validity of 10 days from the date of issuance until arrival at the US port of entry. A certificate issued more than 10 days before the flight is invalid, regardless of whether the endorsement is correct.

Domestic cats entering the United States are subject to a different regulatory framework from dogs. Cats do not require RFFIT or DMRVV risk classification. Requirements are limited to: microchip (recommended but not federally mandatory), proof of rabies vaccination with inactivated vaccine (only required in some states, not at federal level), and a health certificate issued by a veterinarian. However, some states such as Hawaii apply a 120-day quarantine to all felines, regardless of federal regulations. The dog-cat distinction is one of the first clarifications that must be made in the pre-export consultation.

The following details the minimum recommended time sequence for exporting a dog from Peru to the USA under CDC 2024 regulations, assuming the animal has no prior valid rabies vaccination:

Week 0: ISO 11784/11785 microchip implantation. Reading verification with universal scanner. Registration in health record.

Week 0 (same day or within 72h): First dose of inactivated rabies vaccine (product authorized in Peru). Record batch number, expiry date, and administering veterinarian's name.

Week 4 (minimum 30 days post-vaccine): Blood sample collection (2-3 mL of separated serum). Shipment in cold chain to USDA-approved laboratory (e.g., KSVDL in Kansas).

Week 5-6: Receipt of RFFIT result. If ≥ 0.5 IU/mL: proceed. If < 0.5 IU/mL: revaccinate and restart from Week 0.

Week 5-6 (parallel): Begin DogBot registration (dogs.cdc.gov) with all available data. Complete and verify classification.

Week 7-8: Preparation of health certificate (APHIS Form 7001) by SENASA-accredited veterinarian. SENASA validation. USDA endorsement.

Week 8 (maximum 10 days before flight): Final issuance of endorsed health certificate. Confirmed flight reservation. The certificate must not be issued more than 10 days before the date of arrival at the US port of entry.

Travel day: Present at airport with: verified microchip, DogBot QR code, endorsed certificate, original RFFIT result, original vaccination record.

Minimum total timeframe The minimum timeframe from microchip implantation day to boarding, assuming a positive RFFIT result on the first attempt, is approximately 55-65 days. Any RFFIT result < 0.5 IU/mL resets the counter from revaccination.

The most frequent and most serious error: the microchip was implanted after the rabies vaccine. This invalidates the vaccination history associated with that microchip and requires starting a completely new cycle from scratch. APHIS Form 7001 cannot be issued with a vaccine administered before the animal's electronic identification.

No laboratory based in Peru is currently included in the USDA list of approved laboratories for RFFIT valid for US importation. An RFFIT performed at a Peruvian laboratory,

even if technically correct, is not recognized. The result must come from a laboratory explicitly listed by USDA APHIS on its official portal.

The DogBot system automatically validates the consistency of entered data. Any discrepancy between the vaccination date declared in DogBot and that appearing on the physical certificate, or between the microchip number in DogBot and that verified at the port of entry, generates a conditional or non-compliant classification. All documents must be consistent to the last digit.

APHIS Form 7001 is valid for 10 days from issuance to arrival at the port of entry. A flight rescheduled for external reasons (airline cancellation, weather issues) may leave the certificate out of the validity window, requiring re-issuance and re-endorsement with associated costs and delays. It is advisable to coordinate certificate issuance with definitive flight confirmation.

CDC/USDA regulations are federal and apply at the port of entry (airport). However, some states have additional requirements that apply once the animal has entered the country. Hawaii, for example, applies a 120-day quarantine for all dogs and cats, regardless of federal requirements. Always verify the regulations of the final destination state, not just federal requirements.

Clinical evidence -- Zoovet Travel 2013-2026 Over 13 years of managing Peru-USA pet exports, 34% of cases with destination complications originated from microchip-vaccine sequence errors detected too late. The second most frequent group (28%) corresponded to use of non-USDA-approved RFFIT laboratories. The implementation of the DogBot system since August 2024 has significantly reduced rejections at destination, but has transferred complexity to the prior registration and documentary verification process.

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Figure 1. DogBot classification — CDC 2024 Interim Final Rule.

Sequential AND-logic; classification is automated by the dogs.cdc.gov portal prior to flight. Source: CDC IFR, 42 CFR Part 71 (effective 2024-)

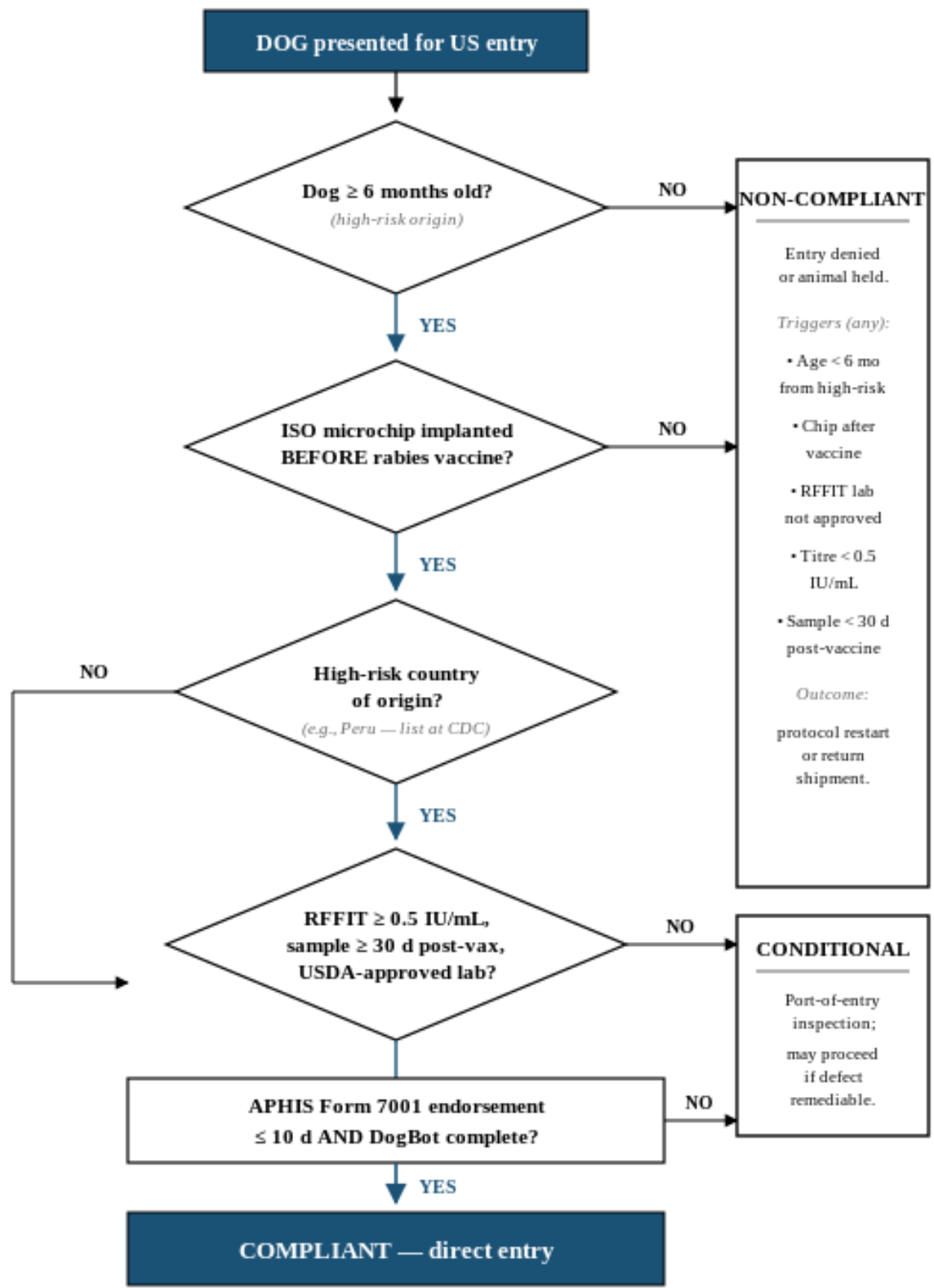
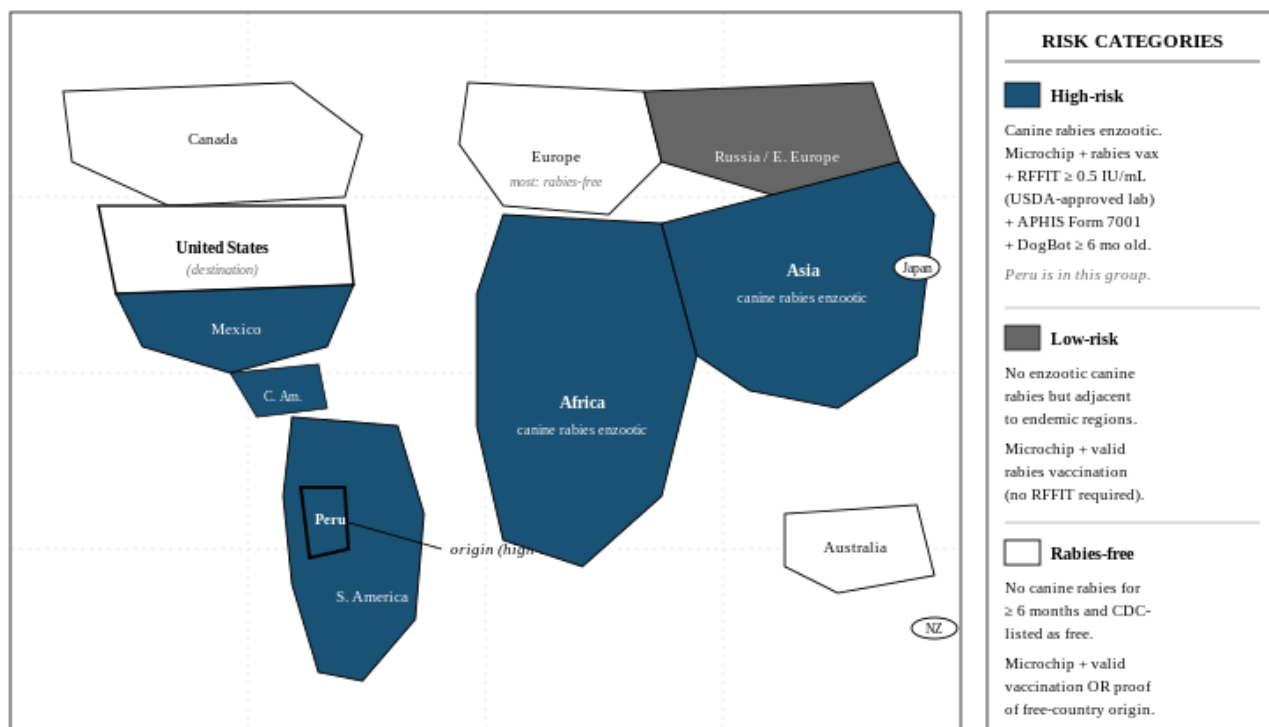


Figure 2. CDC country risk classification for dog importation to the United States (2024).

Schematic categorical map. Source: CDC list of high-risk countries for dog rabies (current at publication). Verify the live list at [cdc.gov](https://www.cdc.gov/importation/dogs/high-risk-countries.html) before each export.



Note — No Peruvian laboratory currently holds USDA-approval status for RFFIT; serum must be shipped to a CDC/USDA-recognised lab abroad.

Country list is dynamic. Verify [cdc.gov/importation/dogs/high-risk-countries.html](https://www.cdc.gov/importation/dogs/high-risk-countries.html) before each export. Map is schematic, not cartographically accurate.

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